

For example, a common use of editing the registry is to remove applications from your startup sequence. You might think that the “msconfig” utility included in all Windows versions might do the trick, however the “msconfig” utility only exposes the tip of the iceberg.

For a better idea of what you put your system through each time you start it, try the “autoruns” utility by Microsoft SysInternals. This utility will list nearly each and every application and dll that the system loads during its boot procedure. It includes not only the applications launched on login, but also components which are loaded by Windows Explorer. Using “autoruns” you can thus remove any unwanted entries which have polluted your right click menu. You can also disable services, disable hardware drivers (might make your system unbootable), disable enabled Windows Vista / 7 gadgets and much much more. While it is certainly possible to do all this straight using the registry, the configuration locations in the registry are too spread out. Another good thing about the “autoruns” utility is that it provides you the registry path for all its settings, so you can use it to find popular registry locations. The Windows registry is like a virtual file system in which you have “keys” and “values” instead of folders and files. A key is reminiscent of a folder in a drive, as it can contain any number of sub-keys (which in turn can host further sub-keys). A key can contain multiple name-data pairs which represent the configuration entries. Each key has a default entry which can also be assigned a value. The data in each name-data pair is typed, i.e. it can only contain data of a certain type. The data types available are String, Binary, DWORD, QWORD, Expandable string and Multi-string. Just like you have with your filesystem, the registry also uses paths to specify the location of any particular key.

To edit the Windows registry, the simplest tool to use -- one which is free and works reasonably well -- is the registry editor which comes bundled with Windows: `regedit`. It can be launched using the Run dialog (Windows Button + R) by entering the command `regedit` and hitting [Enter].

The Windows registry in any recent OS will display the following 5 root key entries:

- HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT
- HKEY_CURRENT_USER
- HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE
- HKEY_USERS
- HKEY_CURRENT_CONFIG

All these settings are not stored in a single file, but are instead spread across multiple files in logical groups called “hives”. The combination of data from these “hives” makes up the Windows registry. The key to hacking your registry is to understand where everything goes. Let us look at the kind of settings stored in each of these sections to gain a better